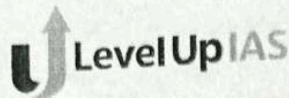


Q.2c (15 marks): How do descent theories and alliance theories differ in their approaches to understanding kinsh...



(Don't Write anything in this Area)

4.c) How do descent theories and alliance theories differ in their approaches to understanding kinship and social organization? (15 marks)

Kinship refers to socially recognised three or future ties.

Various approaches were outlined to study these ties and the existing social organisations.

Descent theory

→ Given by Meyer Fortes and Graebner-Pritchard and popularised after their study 'The African Political system' (1940)

Premise → The theory argues that in societies with unilineal descent groups, the groups act as corporations, as all kinds of economic, political, social activities are guided by the group.

(A) Classical
↳ Patrilineal theory

↓
By Henry Maine

↳ promiscuity theory

Example → In their study among Nuers, Pritchard observed this as lineage was important for all the encompassing life.

(B) Modern

↳ R.C. Brown

in Study of Australian
tribe placed descent
group at centre.

By McLennan & Morgan

Alliance theory

→ Given by Claude Levi-Strauss in his 'Elementary structures of Kinship' (1949)

Premise → Levi-Strauss argues that marriage is a system of reciprocity as exchange of women leads to formation of alliances and this forms the basis of kinship and social organisation

→ He argued that exogamy and universal incest taboo forms the basis of alliances. as groups marry-outs to reduce threats.

Example - A Ravidhara village has 220 households from which women have come from neighbouring villages and 226 households to which women of village have gone. (Goode, 1970)

Difference in two theories

- 1) Descent theory does not consider other groups. not in kinship and social organisation, while alliance theory does.

Relevant point

- 2) Alliance theory is derogatory to women (L. Rubin), while descent theory is not.
- 3) Descent theory considers intra-group solidarity and gave it as basis of kinship, while alliance theory considers inter-group solidarity.

Both the theories, however different in their approach laid the basis of study of kinship and social organisation and contributed to field of anthropology.

$$\frac{7\frac{1}{2}}{15}$$